

Module 10: Migration, Labor, and the Economy

Graduate Research Project

Designing Economic Inclusion: A Strategy and Evaluation Framework

Overview

Design an economic inclusion strategy for a specific migrant population in a specific place — grounded in evidence on what works — and build the evaluation framework that would test it.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Design economic inclusion strategies (Grad 1)
- Evaluate labor policy impacts (Grad 2)

Sample research questions

- What binding constraints (credential recognition, work authorization, banking access, discrimination) most limit your chosen population's livelihoods?
- Which interventions have credible evidence of easing those constraints elsewhere?
- How would you know your strategy worked — what outcomes, measured how, compared to what?

Methods

Evidence review (ILO, World Bank, IRC/J-PAL livelihood evaluations) plus local labor market analysis from public data. The strategy must include a theory of change and a realistic evaluation design (indicators, comparison logic, timeline).

IRB / research ethics

Not required for the design; required later only if the strategy were field-tested with human subjects.

Deliverables

- 4,500-word strategy paper with theory-of-change diagram
- Evaluation framework matrix
- Funder-style two-page executive summary

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Evidence base for chosen interventions 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: evidence base for chosen interventions is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: evidence base for chosen interventions is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: evidence base for chosen interventions is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: evidence base for chosen interventions is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Coherence of the theory of change 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: coherence of the theory of change goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: coherence of the theory of change is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: coherence of the theory of change is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: coherence of the theory of change is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Rigor of the evaluation design 30%	Method is rigorous and transparent: rigor of the evaluation design is fully documented, choices are justified, limitations are stated, and another student could replicate the work from what is written.	Method is sound: rigor of the evaluation design is documented and mostly justified, with limitations acknowledged; small gaps would not change the findings.	Method is partial: rigor of the evaluation design is described but under-documented or inconsistently applied, leaving findings plausible but not checkable.	Method is absent or unsound: rigor of the evaluation design is missing, undocumented, or applied so loosely that the findings cannot be trusted.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Executive summary quality 15%	Communication is publication-ready: executive summary quality is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: executive summary quality is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: executive summary quality is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: executive summary quality is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.